Fintech Hackathon

MENTOR GUIDE · LONDON · 13 OCTOBER 2026

Ask, don't drive.

Teams have under two hours. Don't fix their code. Ask the question that helps them cut scope, name a real user and protect the demo.

1 One question at each stage

18:30 **Form teams**
"Who is it for, and what one thing will you show?"
Pair up solo builders.

18:45 **Start building**
"Could anyone build this in a weekend?"
Push for something new early.

19:00 **Build check**
"What works end to end right now?"
Find the one blocker. Mock the rest.

20:00 **Finish and record**
"What does the 1:30 video need?"
No new features. Keep a backup take.

20:20 **Ten-minute warning**
"Is your entry in?"
Entries close at 20:30 sharp.

2 Where teams get stuck

Too many features	→ One person, one problem, one flow.
No clear user	→ Name a real person and their money problem.
Feels generic	→ Ask what is new. Reuse Open Banking or credit data.
AI code breaks	→ Rerun the main flow on fresh data. Check logins and secrets.
Demo fails	→ Mock slow calls. Keep a backup recording.
Quiet or new	→ Agree roles early. Praise small wins.

3 Do and don't

Do

- Ask, listen, let them choose
- Say when you'll be back
- Help pick roles and a narrator
- Name a strength before a fix

Don't

- Take the keyboard
- Pitch your own idea
- Push a pivot after 19:30
- Solve it for them

4 The 1:30 demo

0:00	"Meet [name]. [Their money problem]."
0:15	"Until now [this was hard]. Now [what changed]."
0:25	One flow, live. The wow moment by 1:00.
1:05	"Real: [this]. Mocked: [that]."
1:20	Who pays, and why. Stop at 1:30.

"It feels better to have something small working at the end than something big that's in shambles."

Jarek Wojciechowski, Atomic Object, on mentoring hackathon teams